been used to convey messages in a way that script signs did in more sophisticated forms.

The meanings encoded in the Maski graffiti marks remain unknown, and no potsherds with Brahmi inscriptions have been found here. Yet there is every possibility that by the third century BCE some people in Maski were familiar with the Brahmi script signs, which they may well have seen on the cultural equipment of contemporary groups further south and west. So, even if this was the first time that the king had made his presence felt in this form in the neighbourhood of their settlement, such inhabitants would have recognized the script in which his message was engraved.

The area possesses many gneissic hills and outcrops; the provincial officials responsible for engraving Ashoka's message chose the largest and most conspicuous of these hills, in whose shadow Maski stood. Unlike many other sites in Karnataka where both the first and second minor edicts were set into rock faces, here only the first message of the emperor, Minor Rock Edict I, was found engraved. But instead of a rock face near the settlement, the message was inscribed some distance away, on its western face, making it invisible to the local population. Importantly, it was not even visible to those who passed that part of the Durgada Gudda ridge. This is because Ashoka's message was written inconspicuously, on an interior-facing outcrop of a rock shelter with a massive ledge above it. It was not as if other rocky outcrops were not available. Much nearer the settlement area and beyond it were more accessible rock faces than this one, which is rather too thoroughly tucked inside a cavern on the slope of Durgada Gudda.

So why was this particular rock face chosen for the edict? One possibility is that the local officials entrusted with the task wanted the emperor's message to survive for as long as possible, and the protection offered by the overhanging ledge made them glance favourably at the location. Simultaneously, this was a location conducive to community rituals and local festivals. Such conjecture can only be affirmed or rejected